In “Rethinking Design Thinking: Empathy Supporting Innovation,” McDonagh and Thomas talk about how empathy helps designers understand people and make better things. In “Empathy Machines as Appropriation Machines,” Robert Yang explains how games and VR can make people think they understand others when they do not know their full story. To me, designing with empathy means thinking about what other people need and making things that help them. I think it is more about understanding people first, not just making them feel something. My way of designing is a mix of both authors’ ideas.

Both authors agree that designers should care about real people and their lives. McDonagh and Thomas (2012) explain that designers should watch and listen to people and talk with them to understand what they need (p. 460). This is better than just guessing what people want. Yang has a different view about games and VR. He says, “At best, VR can only offer the illusion of empathy” (Yang, 2017). He worries that players may think they understand someone’s life when they do not know the full story. He also says, “A better empathy should center people, not machines or industries or brands” (Yang, 2017). The main difference is that McDonagh and Thomas focus on understanding people to make better designs, while Yang worries that empathy games may make players feel something without really helping others. I think both readings are useful because design should help people, but we should not think a game can teach us everything about another person’s life.

I think McDonagh and Thomas support empathy because they want designers to make things that help people in real life. When designers understand what people need, they can make products that are easier to use and more helpful. They also explain that designers can build trust by having informal conversations with people (McDonagh & Thomas, 2012, p. 460). I think this is important because people may share more when they feel comfortable. Yang is worried because a game may make the player feel sad or happy without helping the person whose story is being told. I think real people should get a chance to share their own stories so others can learn from them.

The idea “People + Technology = Possibilities” connects to both readings. For McDonagh and Thomas, people and technology can work together to make better things that help users. For Yang, technology like VR can help people learn, but it

can also make them think they understand someone's life when they do not. I think technology can be useful if we use it in the right way. My Himalayan hut VR game is an escape room made in ShapesXR. In the game, a blizzard traps a climber inside a mountain hut. The player needs to solve puzzles, fix a broken radio, and call a rescue helicopter before it gets dark. I want players to have fun and also learn about the mountains of Nepal. I want to include real things like prayer flags and mountain life. I can use my own knowledge of Nepal, but I should also do research and learn from people who live in the mountains. If I am not sure about something, I will check good sources or ask people who know more about it. I want my game to show Nepal and its culture in a true and respectful way. This also connects to Yang's idea that empathy should put real people first, not just the game or the people who make it.

When I think about both readings, I agree with parts of each one. I agree with McDonagh and Thomas because design should help people and make things easy for them. For example, in my website class project, I need to make a website that is simple so people can find things easily. I also agree with Yang because we cannot fully know how other people feel just by playing a game. We are not living their real life. However, I think Yang is a little too negative about empathy in games because games can still help people learn about others. In my Himalayan hut VR game, I know players cannot learn everything about mountain life from one game, but they can still learn something new.

In the end, I think empathy is important in design, but we should use it in the right way. We should listen to real people and not think we know everything about them. A game or a design can help people learn, but it cannot show everything about real life. Good design should help people and respect their stories.

References

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I have not use any Ai.